

Escaping to never neverland!

Those of you who've been following this column regularly would know that apart from technology, the field of psychology interests me immensely. It may not seem apparent, but the study of the mind, human behaviour, its quirks and technology are quite closely related. Think about it, if technology is the practical adaptation of science, won't human behaviour play a major role because it is, after all, people for whom this adaptation is taking place?

While coming up with the cover story idea for this month, and in turn researching it, each one of us – Robert, Jayesh and I – went off on an individual tangent of sorts. Virtual Reality, that way, is great food for thought. Like the pundits of the '90s, who were probably trying to comprehend the significance of the Internet when it took off or of the smartphone when it hit the scene, we too are at the ground zero of a big paradigm shift. I naturally thought of the psychological ramifications of a world where the lines between the real and virtual are blurred.

Real life is tough; there are challenges, there's pain, there's difficulty, you can't just get what you want when you want it. Some would argue that this is what makes life interesting. That without the bitter, the sweet ain't sweet. But mankind's desire for having it easy has been well known. Every technological innovation that's been fostered till today has been geared towards making life easier. I'm not just talking about physical effort. We're pro-convenience even when it comes to psychological gratification. Need some information? It's a Google search away. Need to be entertained? Put on a cat video. Need companionship? Fire up Tinder, or worse, Chatroulette.

Against such a backdrop, think about what Virtual Reality can, nay, will offer. Your every desire, every fantasy, every need can be fulfilled in that un-real realm. Would you ever want to come out of it? You might have heard of that famous experiment involving rats implanted with electrodes directly stimulating the pleasure center of their brain. The 1950s experiment found that these rats would repeatedly press the lever that activated the electrode, choosing to do so over the lever

that dispensed food and water, eventually dying from exhaustion. Could we be these rats in the making?

Thankfully, people are thinking about the psychological effects of this emerging technology. One such endeavour, which seems part stunt and part experiment, sees artist Mark Farid confining himself to 28 days of self-imposed VR life. The experiment aims to discover the effects of long-term exposure to virtual reality on people. If his Kickstarter campaign is successful, Mark will wear a VR headset for the duration of the experiment and only experience life through another person's eyes and ears. This other person is just some ordinary Joe who's required to wear a pair of glasses that covertly capture audio and video. This footage will constantly be streamed to Mark, who will inhabit a space consisting of only a bed, a toilet and a shower area. He'll eat when the other person, whose visual stimulus he's receiving, eats, he'll sleep when that person sleeps and he'll only be able to hear what that other person is hearing. The socio-psychological aspects of the experiment aim to see if Mark will begin to lose his own sense of self, and start to inhabit the reality of the other person. Most likely he'll go nuts, but still, as long as he's a willing lab rat we're not complaining.

A similarly gimmicky experiment known as the 'Gender Swap Experiment' aims to let one gender experience life in the other's shoes, eventually hoping to make humans get along better.

Clearly, as with any technology there will be highs and lows, the good and the bad but eventually, how we shape our interaction with this new paradigm will determine the direction it will take. What are your views on this brave new future? Write in to editor@digit.in, in to share your thoughts. In the meantime, here's wishing you Season's Greetings and a Happy New Year. 🍷



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Got feedback about this column?
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